figure of the Jewish merchant likely personified a small but apparently thriving Jewish community at Jam-Firuzkuh, established there by the first half of the eleventh century and remaining active until the Mongol campaigns of the 1220s.

Juzjani also highlighted in his story the friendly and mutually beneficial interaction between Amir Banji and the Jewish merchant from Ghur, probably evoking the tenor of relations between the pre-imperial Shansabanis and Jam-Firuzkuh's Jewish inhabitants. In studies of modern transhumant and nomadic groups, large and small transactions have been documented as *de rigueur* between them and farmers, villagers, and townspeople along their seasonal migration routes. In fact, the necessary regularity of these routes even enabled the mutual extension of credit.[88] Thus, it is not implausible that, during the Shansabanis' perennial transhumance to and from their *sard-sir* "home," they developed trading partnerships with the Jewish mercantile community already settled there. In the end, Jam-Firuzkuh benefited the increasingly ambitious Shansabanis, displacing Qala'-yi Zarmurgh as a prominent *sard-sir* destination and eventual summer "capital" by the mid-twelfth century. Jam-Firuzkuh's commercial–economic potential may have been uneven, but any *access* to this potential required mediation, which was embodied in the locality's Jewish merchants and others with skills related to mercantilism.

Large nomadic confederacies from the Eurasian Steppes were undergoing various types and degrees of Islamization already by the tenth century CE, diversifying Islam itself as a political and religious ethos. Prominent among these neophytes were the Saljuqs of greater Iran and eventually Anatolia, who came to dominate the very centers of Islamic religio-political authority embodied in the Abbasid *khalifa* at Baghdad. With the nearly 150-year Saljuq presence spanning from Baghdad *via* Isfahan to Marv (mid-eleventh through twelfth centuries), nomadic lifeworlds combined with the Abbasids' Perso-Islamic imperial and administrative cultures to create palpable distinctions between the western and eastern Islamic lands.[89] Although less of a direct threat to Baghdad itself, the Ghaznavids represented another noteworthy group of empire-builders of the period, *viz*. ancestrally Turkic military slaves whose fantastic territorial gains earned them an enduring reputation over the centuries.[90]

Overlapping temporally and geographically with the Shansabanis, the Saljuqs and Ghaznavids were not only their formidable competitors in imperial expansion, they also served as aspirational models of prevalent courtly cultures (see Chapter One). Each of these three important pre-Mongol political formations of the eastern Islamic lands accommodated Perso-Islamic models of empire and imperial expansion on their own terms, responding to their respective pre-imperial histories, the demands of their political geographies, and the subjects constituting their respective political formations. For the rising Shansabanis, then, similarly